

Gravitas Majlis

A governance and comprehension environment for Shariah boards
supervising on-chain policy — concept document

Working name. Prepared by: Abdusamed Zelić, Gravitas Protocol · July 2026 · Confidential
This component is deliberately outside the current pre-seed round. It is planned as the first major addition following mainnet launch, and is described here so that the scholars who would use it can shape it before it is built.

1 • The problem this addresses

Gravitas makes an approved ruling enforceable at the moment of execution. That solves one problem and creates another: if a rule now has direct operational force, then the process by which a rule is proposed, understood, debated, approved and amended becomes the most sensitive part of the entire system.

Today that process is informal. A board discusses; a decision is minuted; someone conveys it to a technical team; the technical team implements what it understood; and the board has no means of confirming that what runs is what it decided. Every party acts in good faith and the gap remains.

Two further difficulties compound it. First, scholars are asked to rule on mechanisms they have had no opportunity to study, described to them in language built for engineers. Second, the mechanisms change — a protocol issues a new version with materially different behaviour, and no one tells the board that a ruling issued two years ago now attaches to something that no longer works the way it did.

Majlis is the environment in which those three problems are addressed together: a place where the board understands, decides, and where its decision is the operative act rather than an instruction to someone else.

2 • The governing principle

The vote is the signature.

A scholar's vote in Majlis does not produce a recommendation which someone else then executes. It produces the cryptographic signature which authorises the change in the Policy Registry itself. If the signature is not produced, nothing happens. If it is, nothing further is required from anyone.

This single design decision is what separates a governance instrument from an interface. Any arrangement in which scholars express a view and a technical team afterwards performs the act reproduces exactly the gap the system exists to close — and adds a screen over it.

What the scholar actually signs

The object signed is not a sentence of prose. It is a cryptographic hash of the exact operative parameters as displayed on screen at the moment of voting. The consequence is that the question "was what the board approved the same as what was deployed?" becomes a matter of arithmetic rather than of testimony. The two either match or they do not, and anyone can check.

This also draws the line of responsibility cleanly, which matters for every party:

- The board is responsible for the correctness of the ruling and for the parameters it approves.
- Gravitas is responsible for the fidelity of what is displayed to what is deployed — and that responsibility is discharged by proof rather than by assurance.
- Neither party can quietly assume, or quietly escape, the other's share.

3 · Who uses it, and in what capacity

Scholar (voting member)	Reads the brief, questions it, debates it, votes. Holds signing authority. Cannot alter parameters directly — only approve or refuse what is put before the board.
Chair / Secretary	Sets the agenda, confirms quorum, opens and closes deliberation periods. Does not hold additional authority over the outcome.
Technical liaison	Answers questions of mechanism in writing, within the record. Explicitly holds no vote and no signing key. Present to inform, never to decide.
Institution administrator	For an institution running its own policy set: manages which board governs it, and which rules apply to its own operations.
Auditor / observer	Read-only. Can export the complete record of any decision, including reasoning and dissent, in a signed form suitable for a regulator or an external Shariah audit.

4 · The life of a decision, end to end

This is the sequence in full, because the safeguards live in the detail of it.

(a) A matter arises

Four sources: an institution requests approval of an asset or route; a protocol the board has previously ruled on has changed materially; a periodic review falls due; or a compliance concern is raised, whether by the board, an institution, or the protocol itself.

(b) A brief is prepared

Every matter arrives with the same structure, so that no board member has to hunt for what they need: what is proposed, in plain language; the exact operative parameters; what mechanically occurs when the rule is applied; which existing rules it interacts with

or supersedes; and what is *not* being decided. That last element prevents the common failure in which a narrow technical approval is later treated as a broad endorsement.

(c) Simulation before deliberation

Before the board discusses, it sees consequence. The proposed rule is run against historical activity and the result is stated concretely: had this rule been in force over the last quarter, these transactions would not have proceeded — here they are, and here is why. A threshold ceases to be an abstraction and becomes a set of specific outcomes that can be examined and argued with.

(d) Deliberation

A threaded discussion attached to the matter, in which members may question, cite, disagree and ask the technical liaison for clarification. Everything is retained. A minimum deliberation period applies, so that a matter cannot be carried by whoever happens to be awake.

(e) The vote, with reasoning

A vote is not accepted without a written reason. Dissent is recorded as a first-class part of the record, not omitted for tidiness. Where the board is divided, the division is preserved: it is often the most useful thing in the record five years later, and its absence is what makes most institutional archives useless.

(f) Threshold, then the timelock

When the required signatures are gathered, the change enters the timelock — a defined waiting period, visible to all, during which the rule exists but has no force. It appears in Majlis with a countdown. Any signatory may raise an objection during this window, which halts it and returns it to deliberation. This is the purpose of the delay: not administrative caution, but a genuine opportunity to correct a decision while correction is still costless.

(g) Effect, and permanence

The rule takes effect. It, its reasoning, its dissent, its signatories, its timestamps and its simulation results are retained permanently and are queryable from that day forward.

5 • The asymmetry between restricting and permitting

One design point deserves separate treatment, because it is easy to get wrong and expensive to get wrong.

A delay of forty-eight hours is a protection when the change *permits* something: it gives time to notice that something impermissible is about to be allowed. But the same delay is a hazard when the change *restricts*: if the board discovers that an approved asset has become non-compliant, two days of continued activity is not caution, it is harm.

The two directions are therefore treated differently:

- **Permitting** — full deliberation, full threshold, full timelock. Slow by design.
 - **Restricting or suspending** — a reduced threshold, immediate effect, no waiting period. The failure mode is always toward refusal, which is the safe direction.
 - **Ratification afterwards** — an emergency restriction stands, but must be reviewed and confirmed by the full board within a defined period, or it lapses. This prevents an emergency power from becoming an ordinary one.
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6 • The assistant, and its limits

An assistant within Majlis explains technical matters in ordinary language: what a mechanism does, why it is built that way, what changed between one version of a protocol and the next, and what the practical consequences of a parameter are. It exists because the alternative — a scholar ruling on a mechanism he has been given no fair opportunity to understand — is worse than any risk the assistant introduces.

But it introduces a real risk, and it is precisely the risk this whole system exists to address: a faithful ruling founded on an unfaithful explanation. The following constraints are therefore structural, not editorial.

It does not give rulings. The assistant describes mechanism. It does not state, imply, suggest or estimate whether something is permissible, and it does not summarise the fiqh positions of others in a way that functions as an answer. Where a question turns on a ruling, it says so and stops.

Every explanation carries its source. Each answer links to the specific code, documentation or test it derives from. The scholar can verify the ground of any statement, and is never asked to accept an explanation on the assistant's authority — which it does not have.

Everything is retained. Explanations are part of the permanent record. If an explanation is later found to be wrong, it is possible to identify precisely which decisions rested on it and to reopen them. Without this property, an error becomes undiscoverable, which is the condition under which errors become serious.

Uncertainty is escalated, not smoothed. Where the assistant is not confident, it says so and offers to refer the question to the technical liaison, who answers in writing within the record. A correct answer tomorrow is worth more than a fluent answer now.

7 • The standing brief on technological change

A ruling attaches to a mechanism as it existed when the ruling was issued. Mechanisms change, and nobody presently informs a Shariah board when they do. This is an ordinary and largely unnoticed source of drift, and it accumulates silently.

Majlis therefore carries a curated briefing function — deliberately curated rather than automated, since a feed of everything is equivalent to a feed of nothing. Each item follows a fixed structure:

1. What changed, described mechanically and without evaluation.
2. Why it was changed, in the terms of those who changed it.
3. Which existing rules of this board touch the affected mechanism.
4. Whether any of them may require review — stated as a question for the board, never as a conclusion.

An illustration of the kind of matter this is intended to surface: when a decentralised exchange moved from an earlier design, in which a liquidity position was a fungible token, to a later one in which each position is a distinct non-fungible instrument, the change was presented publicly as an improvement in capital efficiency. It was that. It also meant that moving a position now required a sequence of separate transactions with an outcome that could not be known in advance — which is a question of gharar that arose from an engineering decision and was raised with no board anywhere. That is the class of event this function exists to bring before scholars while it still matters.

Items may be raised by the technical team, by any board member, or by an institution. The board decides what warrants attention; the function only ensures the matter is visible.

8 • Keys: the hardest practical problem

The entire design rests on scholars holding signing authority. It is therefore worth stating plainly that this is the part most likely to fail in practice, and that it fails for human rather than technical reasons. A senior scholar will not carry a hardware device, will not manage a seed phrase, and should not be asked to. Any design that requires it will be quietly abandoned within a month.

The approach

Signing authority is held through threshold cryptography: the key exists in shares, no single share is sufficient, and the scholar authenticates through means already familiar to him — his own device, with biometric confirmation. No seed phrase is ever displayed, because a secret that must be written down is a secret that will be written down badly.

A share may be held under the custody of the scholar's own institution under dual control, where that institution's policy requires it. The arrangement is a matter for each board rather than a condition imposed by us.

Succession, absence, and rotation

These are part of the product, not an afterthought, and each must have a defined answer before the first board is convened:

- **Departure.** Authority is revoked and the quorum recalculated by a vote of the remaining members at a raised threshold.
- **Death or incapacity.** A defined process, agreed in advance with the institution, which does not depend on the individual's cooperation. The alternative is a board that cannot act, which is a worse outcome than any it was protecting against.
- **Prolonged absence.** A member may delegate for a defined period, to a named person, recorded openly. Silent delegation is the thing to be prevented; acknowledged delegation is ordinary and should be supported rather than driven underground.
- **Loss of a device.** Recovery through the remaining shares and the institution, never through the protocol acting alone.
- **Changing the quorum itself.** Requires a higher threshold than any ordinary decision, and a longer waiting period. The rules governing how rules change are the ones most worth protecting.

9 • Difference of opinion

Two boards of standing may reach different conclusions on the same instrument. This is normal in fiqh and any system which cannot accommodate it is not serving scholars but overruling them.

Majlis therefore assumes plurality from the outset rather than accommodating it later:

- Each board governs its own policy set. There is no global answer and no arbitration between boards.
- An institution selects which board governs its operations, and that choice is recorded and visible.
- Where boards differ on a matter, the divergence is displayed as a fact, with the reasoning of each available. It is not resolved, ranked or averaged.
- A board may reference another board's reasoning, and may adopt it explicitly with attribution.

This must be built in from the first line of code. Systems which assume a single truth cannot be persuaded to accommodate several afterwards; they can only be rewritten.

10 • What accumulates

A consequence of the design, rather than a feature of it, is that the record becomes something that does not presently exist anywhere: a body of contemporary rulings on digital finance in which each ruling is joined to its reasoning, its dissent, the exact mechanism it addressed, the operative parameters it produced, and the transactions it subsequently governed.

Every element of that chain is ordinarily lost. Reasoning survives in minutes that are not published; parameters survive in systems nobody reviews; the link between them survives nowhere. What is proposed here preserves the whole chain by ordinary operation, without anyone having to undertake the work of preserving it.

Over years this becomes a reference of real scholarly value, and we would regard the question of whether and how it should be published as belonging to the boards that create it rather than to us.

11 • Practical requirements

Language	Arabic, English and Urdu at launch, with full right-to-left support. Most of the scholars this is built for do their serious work in Arabic; an English-only instrument would be a English-speaking instrument.
Devices	Designed for a phone first. Board members read and vote where they are, not at a desk. Typography and contrast set for extended reading by readers who are not twenty-five.

Notification	Restrained and specific. A matter requiring your vote, a countdown nearing its end, an objection raised. Nothing else. An application which notifies constantly is an application which is muted.
Audit export	A single action produces a signed document: what was permitted on a given date, who approved it, on what reasoning, with what dissent, and the proof that the deployed parameters match the approved ones. This is the artefact an external auditor or regulator asks for.
Continuity	The record is on a public chain and does not depend on our servers, our company, or our continued existence. A governance record which can be lost is not a governance record.

12 · What it is not

- It does not issue rulings, and contains no mechanism by which a ruling could be issued other than by scholars.
- It does not replace the sitting of a board. It carries the record and the operative act; the deliberation itself may occur wherever the board prefers.
- It does not adjudicate between schools or between boards.
- It holds no funds and has no custody of any asset at any point.
- It does not make an impermissible instrument permissible. It governs the rules applied to execution; it says nothing about the merits of what is being executed.

13 · How it would be built

The principal risk in this undertaking is not technical. It is that scholars find it burdensome and do not use it, at which point it is worth nothing regardless of its qualities. The sequence below is therefore designed to earn use before it requires it.

Stage one — read only	The record, the technological briefing, and the assistant. No governance function whatever. Its purpose is to be useful to a board that has taken on no obligation, and to let us discover what is unclear before anything depends on clarity.
Stage two — deliberation	Matters, briefs, simulation and discussion. Votes are recorded but signing remains outside the system. The full process is exercised with nothing yet resting on it.
Stage three — the vote becomes the signature	Signing authority moves into Majlis. This is the point at which it becomes a governance instrument, and it should not be reached until a board has used the earlier stages long enough to trust them.

Stage four — plurality

Multiple boards, multiple institutions, cross-reference between them, and the published reference that follows from the accumulated record.

The first stage would be built with a single board that already knows us — AmanX Advisory — and shaped by their objections rather than by our assumptions. We would rather build slowly for scholars who will use it than quickly for scholars we have imagined.

14 · Open questions

These are unresolved, and are the reason this document is being circulated before anything is built.

- Where a ruling must be given a precision it did not originally require — a threshold, a measurement date, the treatment of a temporary breach — is supplying that precision an act of *ijtihād* belonging to the board, or an operational matter that does not?
 - Should a scholar's signature be personal or institutional? Personal authority follows the man and is clearer; institutional authority survives him and is more robust. We do not know which is correct, and suspect it differs by institution.
 - Does holding operative signing authority alter the nature of a board member's responsibility in a way that should be addressed before rather than after the fact?
 - What is the correct minimum deliberation period? Long enough for consideration, short enough that a genuine matter is not left unaddressed while activity continues under an outdated rule.
 - Should dissenting reasoning be visible to institutions and the public, or retained within the board? Openness serves the record; discretion may serve candour.
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The intention of this document is to be corrected. It describes a system that does not yet exist, addressed to the people who would have to live inside it. Any part of it that a scholar finds burdensome, mistaken, or presumptuous is more useful to us now than after it is built.